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## The Two Names I Answer To

Student copy (project or hand out)

1 At 7:40 in the morning I am Daniela, and by 9:00 I am Dani. The change happens somewhere on the F train, between my mother's kitchen and the elevator on the eleventh floor. My mother fed me eggs and a story about my aunt's knee, all of it in Spanish, the warm kind that slides one word into the next. Then I walked into a glass lobby and flattened my vowels so a man named Greg would not have to lean in to hear me. I have done this for sixteen years. I never decided to.

2 You might expect me, here, to tell you this is a tragedy. The story has a familiar shape: the daughter loses the mother tongue, the office eats the home, something pure gets sanded down for a paycheck. I am supposed to mourn. But I will not hand you that story, because it is not the one I lived, and the tidy version would be a lie I told to sound wise.

3 Here is what is actually true. About 43 percent of the people on this planet speak more than one language every day, roughly 1.5 billion of us, and we do not walk around grieving. We switch. Linguists have a flat, unromantic word for it, code-switching, and they have shown it is not sloppiness or loss but a thing speakers do on purpose, to fit the room, to claim a person, to mean exactly what they mean. I switch to Spanish when my mother is tired. I switch to English when Greg needs a number by noon. I switch to something in between with my cousin, who does both at once. The brain runs both systems side by side; it is not choosing one and killing the other.

4 What the word 'code-switching' got wrong, for me, was the word 'code.' A code is a thing you crack, a secret with a single hidden answer underneath. But the Spanish I speak at the table and the English I speak at the desk are not two disguises over one real face. They are two faces, and both of them are mine. There is a phrase researchers use now, translanguaging, the idea that a bilingual person is not running two separate machines but one wide one. I read that and felt seen, which is an embarrassing thing to admit about a journal article.

5 I will not pretend the switch is free. There is a cost the textbooks name and I can feel: the small tax of deciding, every hour, who gets which version of me. On the worst days I have stood in that glass lobby and felt the old thing the linguists call linguistic insecurity, the suspicion that the Spanish makes me less, that Greg's English is the real currency and mine is the soft money. My father, who only speaks English, used to call the firm 'the big leagues.' He meant it kindly.

6 So I am not going to tell you to pick a language and be whole. I wish you two kitchens. I wish you the eggs and the spreadsheet, the vowels you flatten and the ones you let spread out warm. I wish you a self too big for one room. The research says people who lose one language to keep the other tend to belong

less, in both places, not more. I believe that, though I mostly believe my mother, who has never read a study and switched to English on the phone today, for me, badly, and on purpose.

### **AP-style multiple choice:**

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1. In the second paragraph, the writer names the 'familiar shape' of the story (the daughter losing the mother tongue, the office eating the home) primarily in order to
  - A) concede that her own experience matches the conventional account of cultural loss
  - B) set up an expected interpretation she will then refuse, so her actual claim arrives as a correction of it
  - C) establish her credibility by showing she has read the scholarship on language shift
  - D) appeal to readers' emotions by dwelling on the sadness of a lost heritage language
2. In the fourth paragraph, the shift from 'A code is a thing you crack' to 'They are two faces, and both of them are mine' best supports which claim about the writer's tone toward her two languages?
  - A) She remains anxious that one language will always undermine the other
  - B) She moves from treating them as a problem to be solved toward an unforced acceptance of holding both
  - C) She becomes coolly analytic, treating her identity as a linguistics case study
  - D) She grows defiant, insisting her Spanish is superior to the English her workplace rewards

### **Discussion questions:**

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1. The writer sets up the 'tragedy' version of her story and then refuses it. What does she offer the reader instead, and why might she consider the refused version 'a lie I told to sound wise'?
2. Trace how the writer redefines the word 'code.' How does shifting from 'a thing you crack' to 'two faces' change what code-switching means in the piece, and does the personal evidence earn that redefinition?

### **Writing prompt (Homework or extended in-class, Q2 rhetorical analysis):**

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The following passage is a first-person reflection by a bilingual professional on switching between Spanish at home and English at work. Read the passage carefully. Then, in a well-developed essay, analyze the rhetorical choices the writer makes to convey her changing understanding of what it means to move between her two languages. In your response you should do the following: respond to the prompt with a defensible thesis that analyzes the writer's rhetorical choices; select and use evidence to support your line of reasoning; explain how the evidence supports your line of reasoning; and demonstrate an understanding of the rhetorical situation.